

The Book of Acts

By Dn Yonnas · Scripture · Youth & Young Adults

Summary

Acts is the 'Gospel of the Holy Spirit' — the story of the Spirit acting through the Apostles to build the Church. The lesson covers Pentecost, St. Peter and St. Paul, the conversion of the Ethiopian eunuch (Acts 8), the cost of witness in St. Stephen's martyrdom, conflicts inside and outside the Church, and the Jerusalem Council as the blueprint for how the Church resolves disputes in Synod.

Lesson Objectives

- See the Holy Spirit as the true main character of Acts
- Explain the significance of Acts 8 for the Ethiopian Church
- Learn the apostolic pattern: preaching, repentance, baptism, communion, trial, multiplication

Key Bible Verses

Acts 1:8 — "you shall receive power when the Holy Spirit has come upon you"

Acts 2 — the descent of the Holy Spirit at Pentecost

Acts 8:26–39 — Philip and the Ethiopian eunuch; cf. Psalm 68:31

Main Teaching Points

- Acts is not a biography of men but of the Holy Spirit working through the Apostles
- The Church is born in prayer, worship, and the Breaking of Bread
- The Ethiopian eunuch's baptism fulfills 'Ethiopia shall stretch out her hands to God'
- Persecution became a refiner's fire — St. Stephen's martyrdom spread the Gospel rather than stopping it
- Ananias and Sapphira warn against spiritual counterfeit; Acts 6 shows the Church confronting tribalism
- The Jerusalem Council (Acts 15): the Church decides in council, not by private interpretation

Key Terms

- **Pentecost** — The descent of the Holy Spirit upon the Apostles (Acts 2), fifty days after the Resurrection — the birth of the Church's public witness.
- **Tsega** — Grace — in Oriental Orthodox understanding, the divine energy and life-giving power of God, not a mere concept.
- **Synod (Council)** — The gathered Church deciding matters of faith together, as in Acts 15 — the opposite of private interpretation.
- **Martyr** — A witness unto death; St. Stephen (Acts 6–7) is the first martyr of the Church.

Discussion & Reflection

- Why is it important that the Church was born in prayer and not in a committee?
- What does the story of the Ethiopian eunuch mean for our identity as Ethiopian Orthodox Christians?
- How does the Jerusalem Council guide the Church when conflict arises today?

Glory be to the Father, the Son, and the Holy Spirit, one God. Amen.